



INDIEFFERENTIAL

WHAT'S NEW?

by indiefferential

E.LISSA FADEN | SEPTEMBER VOL .4 2026

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WELCOME TO INDIEFFERENTIAL

Do you remember that time you discovered your favorite band? What was that like? How did it feel? Over the years we have found different ways of discovering new music and other formats of entertainment. Some of you already remember the first time you bought a vinyl record or a CD.

For me, it was one of the best experiences when I bought an AC/DC CD freshly bought ready to be played at full volume in my parent's Hi-Fi system. The physical aspect of the release always was something that stayed with me for a long time and I loved the whole experience of having that CD, inserting it into the system, controlling the volume and listening to my favorite tracks over and over again. Everything that came along with the CD was a bonus, you could look at pictures, read about the band and have something to do while experiencing their music.

Right now most music is released in digital formats and you can't really experience this. Magazines were also something that introduced me to my favorite bands back in the day. I remember reading about the Killers long before listening to their hits on the radio. Still, the physical aspect of the discovery was significant, for me at least. Of course, it's a lot easier to find out great music these days and not buy seven different CDs to discover what you like.

Enough with the past though, let's move to today, you can stream music, films and series and many people don't bother buying magazines or CDs. I am one of these people who loves to collect things and I also own many video games in digital and physical format. Even though some of my favorite video games are in a library on my computer, I always cherish the time I take to look through the case of an older video game, its pamphlets and artwork.

This is one of the reasons we started Indiefferential. The experience of holding a physical magazine in your hands, reading about these new bands from the other side of the world while you listen to their music online sending them a DM that you love their work. This is what Indiefferential is all about, keeping the good aspects of physical releases and combining this experience with the modern opportunities technology provides.

Indiefferential is here for every artist out there, we love what we do and we will keep posting about your music and projects so people can find out their new favorite artist. Our plan is to post consistently about new artists and creators, in that way, your audience will find out about another great band and their audience will discover your work. This is how Indiefferential works, always supporting artists in order to find the right audience and have their work sent across the whole world.

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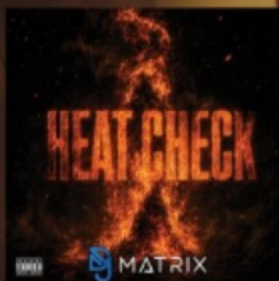


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DJ Matrix turns a hot chapter into a cinematic soundtrack.

DJ Matrix has spent nearly two decades carving the history of an underground dance, and his return to music has led him to a new chapter in his career. His latest release, "Heat Check," is a cinematic soundtrack that captures the essence of the underground scene.

That changed when Egyptian Lover reached him down and encouraged a return, resulting in "Epic" in 2013. A collaboration with that Italian founder (Lover followed with "Red My Face" (2014/2015)), giving the signature track a new lease on life while reconnecting Matrix with the audience that has never forgotten it.

New comes "Heat Check," a more contemporary dancefloor statement that carries the confidence of an artist rediscovering his momentum. Matrix's electronic approach remains rooted in rhythm and physical energy, but the production reflects a willingness to move forward rather than simply rehash the past.

With plans to steadily single leading toward a full album, Matrix is making an unexpected second act into a solidified comeback. "Heat Check" captures that renewed purpose, bringing a vision of early electronic dance back into the present with plenty of energy left to spend.



Keanu Galang finds quiet beauty in the art of letting go.

Keanu Galang explores heartbreak through a sound that sits comfortably between indie pop, neo soul, and intimate singer-songwriter work. With seven months between social media and reflective writing, Galang creates a work that feels intimate and emotional, though with honesty rather than nihilism.

"If I Die" opens a new chapter in that journey, focusing on the difficult acceptance that comes when someone you once imagined a future with is no longer part of it. The song carries the weight of deep attachment while gradually moving toward release, finding resolution in the realization that letting go can also be an act of self-preservation.

Influences from David Byrne, Frank Ocean, and J. Cole that can be felt in the track's restrained emotional delivery and understated search, but Galang's approach remains so real. The production leaves space around the vocal, allowing the lyrics and subtle instrumental details to carry the emotional narrative.

Galang then presents heartbreak in a kinder manner. "If I Die" explains the slow process of acknowledging, working, and rebuilding. It introduces an artist's emotional complexity and vulnerability, setting the listener on a tender musical journey about healing, self-discovery, and finding yourself again.



EPIC NELSON shows endless passion with Death Fever.

EPIC NELSON has been the brightest star of rock and roll with "Death Fever," a spirited summer track built around soaring vocals, driving guitar lines, and hooks that run straight to the listener's heart. The Bay Area band's latest release captures the larger-than-life character of 1960s arena rock while keeping its roots in rock foundation and modern indie sensibility intact.

At the heart of the song is a simple desire: escaping routine, gathering the people you love, and finding someone who's enough to forget the clock. That emotion also shapes the track itself, with vibrant harmonies and energetic guitar work creating the sensation of open roads, ocean air, and long evenings without an agenda.

For Nelson's vocals give the track its celebratory energy, while the guitars provide much of its heat, moving between melodic and expressive solos. Rather than trying to outdo a previous piece, EPIC NELSON use the sound of classic arena rock as a blueprint for something different, joyful, and timeless.

"Death Fever" captures the beauty of the moment that helps people together. It is upbeat without losing its rock edge, polished enough for the studio but clearly built with the live stage in mind. For EPIC NELSON, summer has never been more than a setting, it becomes a state of mind.

FEATURE

Forget the Main Quest: Moose Wrench Find Glory in the Detour



Somewhere between the Nevada desert and the rainy streets of Leeds, a trio calling themselves Moose Wrench decided that the side road was always more interesting than the highway. That philosophy now has an anthem. Their new single, "Mr. Sidequest," lands on 30th September 2026, and it distills the band's entire worldview into three irreverent minutes: the idea that life's richest rewards rarely come from chasing the obvious goal, but from the strange detours taken along the way.

The song's origin is disarmingly personal. It grew out of an offhand comment made by Dr. Moose's own child, who observed that his father had never really pursued life's "main quest," preferring instead to busy himself with sidequests. Rather than treating that as a criticism, Moose Wrench turned it into a creed. "Mr. Sidequest" celebrates the tangents, the wrong turns and the wandering pursuits that, in hindsight, often matter more than the destination ever did.

Recorded at Old Cider Studios under the guidance of veteran producer Dave Draper, the track carries the band's signature blend of Primus-inflected groove and the genre-hopping unpredictability of Mr. Bungle and Ween. It lurches and pivots without warning, refusing to settle into a single mood, which feels entirely appropriate for a song about refusing to settle into a single path.

That restlessness runs through the band's identity as a whole. Moose Wrench describe themselves as a trio of lost souls from the dark places betwixt time and space, purveyors of what they call existential dad-bod alt-core, a sound built to grapple with the unglamorous indignities of getting older: poor driving, man flu, the slow creep of midlife bewilderment. Their origin story, delivered with a wink, has them fleeing a flock of flying monkeys across the Nevada desert before landing, moose-footed, in Leeds, where they now perform their particular brand of suffering so audiences don't have to.

It would be easy to file all this under novelty, but underneath the absurdist framing is a real musical ambition, one built on tight interplay, sudden left turns and a refusal to take the easy route through a song any more than through life. "Mr. Sidequest" practices exactly what it preaches: it wanders, it detours, it forgets the expected trajectory entirely, and in doing so becomes something far more memorable than a straight line ever could.

The band's collaboration with Dave Draper at Old Cider Studios seems to matter here too, giving the wildness of the arrangement a solid, well-recorded foundation rather than letting it collapse into pure chaos. There is craft underneath the comedy, structure underneath the shape-shifting, and a clear sense that every abrupt pivot has been placed exactly where it needs to be. For a band built on embracing the tangent, that might be the whole point: the detour, it turns out, was the plan all along.



SCAN TO LISTEN
INDIEFFERENTIAL



Rhythm, Synth, Surrender: Inside The New Citizen Kane's Neon World

Some artists write songs. The New Citizen Kane builds worlds. Working as an independent artist, Kane has spent several releases constructing a multi-sensory pop universe where emotion, identity and instinct collide, treating every project not as a simple collection of tracks but as an immersive narrative stretched across sound, visuals and performance.

That world-building instinct traces back to a background in theatre and multidisciplinary art, which shapes how Kane approaches songwriting itself. Blending synth-pop and electronic textures with cinematic storytelling, the music circles around the contradictions of being human: desire pressed against restraint, chaos pressed against control, connection pressed against isolation. It is pop music made by someone who thinks in scenes as much as in choruses.

THE STORY

The journey has unfolded in chapters. After the electric debut *It's Not Science... It's A Feeling*, Kane

moved through the dreamlike introspection of *The Tales of Morpheus* and the kaleidoscopic awakening of *Psychadelika Pt.1*. Now comes *Psychadelika Pt.2*, a more confrontational and confident phase that pushes deeper into instinct, systems, intimacy and survival. It marks the fullest expression yet of what Kane calls "rhythm & synth," a sonic identity built on the premise that physical movement and emotional intelligence are inseparable.

Lead single "Metallic" introduces this new era with a surge of nocturnal energy, a hypnotic, neon-lit anthem about surrendering to feeling and letting instinct take control. It sets the tone for a project that promises to be bolder and sharper than what came before, more unfiltered in its exploration of modern life's contradictions.

Perhaps most striking is how The New Citizen Kane operates entirely outside traditional industry frameworks. Rather than relying on conventional gatekeepers, Kane has built a direct relationship with audiences through visual albums, conceptual

rollouts and a growing digital ecosystem, treating the fanbase as active participants in the unfolding story rather than passive listeners.

What began as a constructed persona has, over time, evolved into something far more personal. Vulnerability, honesty and creative freedom have become Kane's most powerful tools, and *Psychadelika Pt.2* suggests an artist increasingly comfortable letting the mask slip just enough to reveal what's underneath.

That evolution feels central to understanding the project as a whole. Where the earlier chapters leaned into dreaminess and kaleidoscopic wonder, this new phase trades some of that softness for confrontation, without losing the theatrical instinct that has defined Kane's work from the start. In a pop landscape often built on surface and spectacle, The New Citizen Kane offers something rarer: a fully realized universe with a beating, uncertain heart at its center, one still figuring out how instinct and intimacy fit together under neon light, and inviting the audience to figure it out alongside him.

DEEP DIVE

THE WHY IS IN THE RUB: JOHNNY PEARS' MIDNIGHT EXISTENTIAL CRISIS

Some songwriters plan. Johnny Pears waits. Born in South Shields in the UK, Pears channels a deliberately spontaneous style of song composition, treating unpredictability not as a limitation but as his primary creative outlet, the only method he has ever really trusted for making anything half decent.

That spontaneity shapes everything about his process. Rather than sitting down with method or discipline, his material tends to arrive unannounced, scribbled onto scraps of paper or mumbled into a phone as midnight voice memos, half-formed melodies and guitar lines captured in the moment before they disappear, much to the reported annoyance of his partner. It is not a tidy way to work, but it produces something that feels alive and unforced, songs that seem discovered rather than constructed.

His influences, by his own account, are vast and difficult to pin down, surfacing as subconscious nods and layered echoes of contemporaries and predecessors alike rather than any single

traceable lineage. The resulting sound varies from release to release, built from a blend of software, physical instruments and a voice that moves between punchy directness and unexpected harmony, all in service of what Pears frames as a sonic DIY journey of discovery.

"Johnny Pears waits."

That journey finds its sharpest expression yet on new single "Pin Cushion," a song that arrives brimming with existential angst and functions, at its core, as a philosophical pondering on the meaning of life itself. Lines like "A cessation of human conscious, come cremation endless nothing?" sit at the heart of the track's unease, while the chorus refrain "The why is in the rub" offers something closer to a mantra than an answer. Together they turn the song into what might best be described as an existential crisis

rendered for the ears, meandering through the kinds of questions most people push aside but almost everyone quietly wonders about at some point.

There is something disarming about hearing such heavy material delivered without pretension, filtered through a process built on spontaneity rather than careful construction. Pears isn't interested in offering resolution or comfort; "Pin Cushion" sits in its own discomfort and asks the listener to sit there too.

That willingness to let a song stay unresolved feels consistent with everything else about how Pears works. His refusal to be methodical, his comfort with letting ideas arrive however and whenever they choose, extends naturally into lyrics that refuse easy answers as well. It is a song born from midnight scribbles that ends up interrogating the biggest question of all, proof that the most unplanned creative process can still stumble onto something genuinely profound.



SCAN TO LISTEN
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SCENE REPORT

LOVE THAT KEEPS ECHOING: KULLY BATH'S BILINGUAL ODE TO ETERNITY

For Kully Bath, love has never been something that simply ends. It transforms, lingers, and returns in unexpected forms, an idea that sits at the center of her new single, "Tu Goonjhda Rehnda Ae" (You Keep Echoing), released on 11th September 2026. The track marks a significant milestone as her first Punjabi-English fusion release, written, performed and conceptualised entirely by Bath herself.

Following the ethos established on her EP Echoes, the song explores the idea that love transcends time, gradually transforming into spirit, memory and echo long after a relationship has run its course. Its bilingual lyrics paint a vivid picture of an eternal love that persists "within every heartbeat" and lives on "in the colours of nature," weaving together two languages that, despite their differences, share the same emotional depth and cultural richness. Bath has explained that working across both languages allowed her to go deeper with

her songwriting than ever before, using the interplay between them to say things one language alone could not fully capture.

The result is a deeply personal release, one that emphasizes a simple but resonant idea: some love stories never fade. Rather than confining that message to a single cultural or linguistic frame, Bath wraps it in the interplay of Punjabi and English, offering a universal sentiment carried by two distinct musical and emotional traditions at once.

That commitment to authenticity runs through Bath's broader body of work. Described as an award-winning UK-based singer-songwriter, she creates emotionally rich music across Adult Contemporary, Indie and Pop, consistently rooting her songs in lived experience and the defining moments that shape a life. Through introspective,

heartfelt storytelling, she explores vulnerability, resilience and the courage required to heal, writing for listeners who often feel unseen and offering them connection, reflection and strength in return.

Her growing catalogue reflects that evolution, from the Rising Tides EP through Chapters of Destiny, which introduced rap elements into her sound. Her track "Masterpieces from Broken Pieces (RAP Version)" has since found its way into in-store sync placements with Café Nero in Belgium and L'Occitane in Sweden, a sign of a catalogue reaching well beyond streaming platforms alone. With her EP Echoes rolling out across major platforms and now this bilingual single extending its themes further, Kully Bath continues to build a body of work defined by one steady conviction: that real love, once it exists, keeps echoing long after the moment has passed.



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Profile

DIVORCED DAD ROCK AND THE ART OF UNIVERSAL SPECIFICITY



Every great arena rock record tells a personal story loud enough for a crowd to sing along to, and *Blinded By the Blonde: Chapter One* is no exception. The project belongs to D.D.R., short for Divorced Dad Rock, the songwriting outlet of Indiana-based novelist and songwriter Stephen Paul, and across seven tracks it traces an arc through love, betrayal, loss, grief and, ultimately, the decision to feel again.

Rather than simply gathering previously released songs into a compilation, Chapter One places them inside a larger narrative structure, one built with intention. The story moves from the broken promises of "Never Forever" through the betrayal at the heart of "Sleeping With the Enemy," before arriving at the raw, deeply personal "Don't Tell Me How to Grieve." "Make Me Feel Again" closes the collection as its epilogue, offering something closer to resolution than triumph. The whole project combines that kind of intimate storytelling with the big hooks, driving guitars and soaring melodies of classic arena rock.

Paul describes the guiding principle behind D.D.R. as "universal specificity," the idea of telling stories personal enough to feel entirely real while still leaving room for listeners to locate their own experiences somewhere inside them. Influenced by bands including Bon Jovi, Def Leppard, Journey, Warrant and Shinedown, D.D.R. balances powerful melodies with honest lyrics, moving comfortably between anthemic rock songs and emotionally charged ballads. Rather than chasing passing

trends, the project leans into timeless songwriting, memorable choruses and performances brought to life through collaborations with professional musicians from around the world.

The latest single, "Don't Tell Me How to Grieve," pushes that approach further, exploring the heavy silence that follows profound loss through cinematic arrangements, expressive guitar work and a distinctive visual world built around original tarot-style artwork. It reflects Paul's underlying belief that music can give voice to emotions that often defy plain explanation, offering listeners a way into feelings that resist straightforward language.

With Chapter One now closed, D.D.R. is positioned to turn the page toward whatever comes next. The seven-track arc, from broken promise to grief to the decision to feel again, gives the project a shape rarely attempted within arena rock, a genre often more associated with anthems of celebration than with structured emotional narrative.

Whether delivering humor, heartbreak or hard-hitting rock, the project remains anchored to one simple, consistent goal: writing songs built to stay with listeners long after the final note fades, proof that even deeply personal grief can be shaped into something built for a crowd to shout back.



SCAN TO LISTEN
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SHORT FILMS FOR THE EARS: ELIAS DREAM'S CINEMA OF HEARTBREAK

Elias Dream doesn't just write songs; he builds scenes. As a storytelling-driven artist blending rap, melodic vocals, rock influences and cinematic production, Dream constructs songs that unfold like short films, complete with characters, turning points and the kind of emotional stakes usually reserved for the screen. At the heart of the project are stories about love, loss, fear, hope and the difficult decisions capable of changing a life in an instant.

That cinematic instinct is on full display in his latest release, "Goodbye, My Love," which tells the story of a man who suddenly loses the woman he loves in a tragic accident. Rather than simply narrating the tragedy from a distance, the song is built to place the listener directly inside the experience, moving through hope, fear and confusion before arriving at the devastating moment he has to say goodbye. It captures how quickly an entire life can shift, the person someone loves present one moment and gone the next.

THE STORY

Musically, the track sits somewhere between emotional rap, melodic pop and cinematic ballad. The verses carry the narrative forward while the sung sections open up the emotional core, with piano, electric guitar and atmospheric textures building the mood without ever pulling focus away from the story itself. A recurring signature throughout Dream's catalogue is the warm, organic character of a Hammond B3 run through a Leslie speaker, an analogue texture that creates a distinctive contrast against the otherwise modern production, grounding even the most cinematic arrangements in something tactile and human.

The approach extends well beyond songwriting alone. Dream is deeply hands-on across every stage of the process, developing each concept and story, writing the lyrics, shaping the musical direction, handling arrangement and production, and personally overseeing mixing and mastering until each release feels exactly right. It is a level of control that mirrors the precision of the storytelling itself, nothing left to chance in the pursuit of a fully realized emotional world.

Underlying all of it is a clear artistic ambition: songs are not meant to be heard once and forgotten. Dream wants each release to function like a short film experienced with eyes closed, something a listener can return to and still find new detail inside.

That ambition is what makes "Goodbye, My Love" land as more than a simple tragedy set to music. It achieves exactly what Dream sets out to do with every release, a story about love, loss and the words too often left unsaid until it is already too late, delivered with enough cinematic detail that the listener feels present at every stage of it.



RETROSPECTIVE

LEMONADE AND LONGING: GIRLHOOD'S REASSEMBLY IN STROUD



There is a version of growing up that has nothing to do with grand declarations and everything to do with picnics, lemonade and the quiet rituals of an ordinary afternoon. That is the world critically acclaimed indie-pop band Girlhood inhabit on their radiant new single "Lemon Aid," the first glimpse into a fresh, more reflective chapter for the group. The track transforms emotional pressure and quiet recalibration into something gentle, hopeful and life-affirming, an invitation to surrender to the moment, dance until the weight lifts, and find fleeting freedom inside the everyday.

Opening with a nostalgic piano motif, acoustic guitar and a playful sped-up vocal sample, "Lemon Aid" gradually unfolds into a tender, sugar-sweet indie-pop ballad led by singer-songwriter Natalie Holmes. Its gentle rhythms and laid-back groove carry a quintessentially British charm, rooted in the shopfronts, parks, cafés and winding streets of Stroud, the Cotswold town where the band's forthcoming album, *This Will Make Sense In The End*, took shape.

That album marks a defining new chapter for Girlhood. After watching Holmes perform in support of Jesca Hoop, founder, producer and songwriter Christian Pinchbeck was immediately drawn to her voice and invited her to collaborate, a partnership that quickly became transformative following years of remote collaborations with friends-of-friends and guest vocalists. The album itself was

written during a period when Holmes's relationship with dating, love and self-understanding began shifting dramatically, entering her thirties with a new clarity but also a more complex uncertainty about old romantic instincts. That emotional terrain became intertwined with her love of food, woven into songs about attraction, control, hunger, desire and self-preservation, with picnics, breakfasts and fruit recurring like clues hidden in plain sight.

Musically, the record began almost as an experiment: taking forgotten soul records and pushing them until they no longer behaved like samples, reshaping them into new rhythms and emotional landscapes that became the engine driving the whole album. Songs drift between sample-rich, sunlit indie-pop and more fractured, unpredictable territory spanning sparse R&B, acoustic confessionals and moments of cinematic release.

It is, in many ways, a story of reassembly rather than reinvention. Originally formed as Elephant before evolving into Girlhood, the band earned widespread acclaim for their 2014 debut *Sky Swimming*, drawing praise from Clash and Pitchfork and comparisons to Daughter and Camera Obscura, with songs later appearing on Misfits and Lucifer. *This Will Make Sense In The End* feels like the moment two people finally occupy the same room again.



SCAN TO LISTEN
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TWO FLAGS ONE HEART



Few catalogues resist a single genre label quite like Erick Oscar's. Playing acoustic guitar and writing songs for more than thirty years, Oscar grew up listening to music every weekend, usually ballads and love songs, and still treats the guitar the same way today: as therapy, a way to process whatever a given day leaves behind.

His life story explains why his music refuses to sit still. Born in Panama, Oscar has lived in the United States for thirty-four years and became an American citizen decades ago, but work has also taken him to postings across nearly every country in Latin America. That combination of Panamanian roots, an American home and a life spent moving through Latin America is precisely what makes his catalogue eclectic rather than confined to any one sound.

Writing and singing in both English and Spanish, Oscar draws from an unusually wide palette: country, pop, ballads, salsa, merengue,

bachata, flamenco, vallenato, reggaeton and mariachi, among others. Country music occupies a particular place in his affections, one he describes as deep, raw and pure, but the standard he holds himself to remains constant no matter which genre he is working in: the song has to say something. Genre, for Oscar, is a vehicle rather than an identity, chosen based on what a given story or feeling requires rather than any allegiance to a scene.

"His life story explains why his music refuses to sit still."

That range is matched by an equally hands-on approach to craft. Oscar writes all of his own lyrics and works closely with music-production software to build the instrumentation, arrangement and vocal performance around them, a process that has, by his own description, turned him into

something of an amateur producer, one who genuinely loves trying new things rather than settling into a fixed method.

The result is a body of work shaped less by industry convention than by geography and lived experience, songs that move fluidly between languages and traditions because the artist behind them has done the same for most of his life. Where many musicians spend careers refining a single identifiable sound, Oscar's identity is defined by movement itself, by a willingness to follow a song wherever its genre needs to take it. In an era when artists are often pushed toward tight, marketable niches, Erick Oscar stands as a reminder that a career built on borders crossed, rather than genres mastered, can be its own kind of coherent, deeply personal art form.



SCAN TO LISTEN
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Some songs start as a private wish and grow into something much larger. That is the trajectory of "Born To Fly," the new single from Indian American singer-songwriter, composer and producer Seema Farswani, a cinematic soft-rock and global-pop anthem created from Singapore through a cross-border collaboration with musicians from both Singapore and Mumbai. Rooted in courage, empowerment, hope and possibility for girls and women, the track brings together Western rock and South Asian musical textures, weaving soaring guitars, expressive sitar, Hindi vocals and layered contemporary voices into an expansive, cinematic arrangement.

The song was co-produced by Farswani and Rishabh Sharma, a Mumbai-based guitarist, composer and producer active across Bollywood and the wider contemporary music landscape, whose production, arrangement and guitar work lend the track much of its rock-driven scale. The recording also features Ananya Wadkar, a Mumbai-based Neo-Classical vocalist and sitar artist whose expressive playing and soaring Hindi vocals bring a distinctly Indian dimension to the piece, alongside Singapore-based classically trained vocalist Shania Tan, who contributes additional vocal textures. Brandon Leo mastered the final recording. As Farswani has described it, the goal was to build a world where East meets West, where guitars could sit naturally alongside sitar and Indian vocals in service of a simple, central message: every girl should have the courage and freedom to dream beyond the horizon.

The idea behind "Born To Fly" first developed through The Voices Unseen, a charity concert held in Singapore in May in support of people with visual impairments and women's empowerment. What began from a deeply personal place gradually evolved into a wider message for girls and women everywhere, about finding a voice, believing in possibility, and having the courage to rise.

The release marks another step in Farswani's increasingly genre-fluid catalogue, which spans debut EP *Got My Mojo* through releases including *Something's Got a Hold on Me*, *Under A Blazing Sun*, *Sketches on the Walls*, *Season of Gratitude*, *Runways* and an Afro House remix of the same track. Moving across blues, jazz, synth-pop, electro-pop, acoustic fusion and cinematic rock, her music is shaped by a multicultural background and a creative foundation in fine arts and spatial design.

A recipient of the Berklee Aspire 5-Week scholarship and a 2025 ICMA Best Vocalist finalist, Farswani has steadily built an international independent footprint through radio, press, live performance and collaboration across continents, with "Born To Fly" standing as its most ambitious expression yet.

Born To Fly: Seema Farswani's Cross-Continental Anthem for Every Girl



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LONG READ

Come Aboard the Happy Flight: Andrew Shabazz's Love Letter in Sound



Not every love story needs words to be told, and "Happy Flight (Slowed)," the new release from Sharpshooter Soundworks, proves exactly that. Releasing on 25th September 2026, the jazz-infused instrumental track marks a deeply personal milestone, telling the story of a pivotal moment in the life of the artist behind the project, Chicago-based producer and songwriter Andrew Shabazz: the plane journey to meet his wife during their long-distance relationship, and the flight that eventually brought her home to stay.

The composition itself grew organically rather than following a fixed plan. It begins with chord progressions offset by unconventional percussion that breaks from typical four-four patterns, an unsettled rhythmic foundation that mirrors the uncertainty of long-distance love before Shabazz layered basslines and additional instrumentation piece by piece. The result is a track that genuinely takes listeners on a journey of its own, opening with the evocative line, "Won't you take a ride? come on

board my happy flight," an invitation as much as a title.

THE STORY

Described by Shabazz as a labor of love he is particularly proud of, the track captures the euphoria of new love alongside the weight of the life-changing decisions that came with it, all without a single sung verse to spell it out directly. Instead, the emotional arc is carried entirely through instrumentation, letting the listener fill in the story's specifics while still feeling its shape clearly.

Sharpshooter Soundworks is the creative vehicle through which Shabazz has been crafting music across multiple genres for over a decade, working as a self-described multi-genre instrumental artist rather than a multi-instrumentalist, someone drawn to the possibilities of a wide range of styles rather than mastery of many instruments at once. He handles every aspect of the creative process himself, from songwriting and composition to full

production, operating out of his home studio where ideas are transformed into fully realized tracks from start to finish.

That hands-on methodology is driven by a genuine love of experimentation and learning through practice, a willingness to keep pushing into new sonic territory and unfamiliar production techniques rather than settling into a single formula. It has allowed Shabazz to develop a sound that feels distinctly his own while remaining flexible enough to move across different musical landscapes.

The unconventional rhythmic backbone of "Happy Flight (Slowed)," built from percussion that deliberately avoids standard time signatures, is a good example of that willingness to experiment even on a track this personal. "Happy Flight (Slowed)" stands as one of the clearest expressions yet of that philosophy, a wordless story about love, distance and finally arriving home.





The name itself is a statement of intent. Lucian means light, and Lucian Lacewing has built an entire artistic identity around how that light looks filtered through the translucent bodies of lacewing insects, an image that captures precisely the delicate, glowing quality of the music he creates from his bedroom studio in Bristol.

Lacewing blends dreamy synths with muted trumpets, ouds, handpans, sitars and cellos, layering in dubby snippets of voices from eight singers of his acquaintance to create a sound suspended somewhere between ambient music, modern-day psychedelia and nocturnal drone. Drawing inspiration from ambient pioneers Brian Eno and Laraaji, alongside contemporary artists Julianna Barwick and Mary Lattimore, he has developed a distinctive compositional approach rooted in experimentation and spaciousness, favoring atmosphere over structure at nearly every turn. Rather than

performing live, he dedicates himself entirely to composition and remixing, allowing an intuitive creative process to guide each piece toward destinations he could not have predicted at the outset. His stated philosophy is disarmingly simple: begin each project with little idea of the final outcome, and let chance and inspiration meet somewhere in the middle.

That philosophy finds one of its most striking expressions in "Freedom From Forever," releasing on 28th September 2026. The track was built entirely around six or seven randomly selected harp samples, each just a single plucked note, born from a deliberate creative constraint and the question of whether something compelling could be crafted from such limited material. The answer arrived as a mesmerising fusion of ethereal harps, reverberating ouds, trippy synthesizers and bewitching vocal samples from an unknown, multi-octave Kenyan singer. Employing his signature technique of

pairing natural instruments with synthesizers playing identical melodies, Lacewing conjures a mystifying texture that quietly challenges how listeners perceive the line between organic and synthetic sound, resulting in a piece that is both soothing and touched by a subtle, lingering melancholy.

There is, however, one detail Lacewing deeply regrets: his inability to credit or even name the Kenyan singer whose voice anchors the track. Having procured the samples from a royalty-free samples website that has since removed them without explanation or further information, he has been left unable to trace their origin. All he can do now is hope that, wherever she is, she would approve of what has been made from her enchanting voice, a small tension at the heart of a project otherwise built entirely on turning constraint into wonder.

SPOTLIGHT

DRINKIN' BLUE: BLOODKIN'S TRIBUTE TO A FALLEN SONGWRITING PARTNER



Four decades after Bloodkin first emerged from Athens, Georgia, and as founding member Eric Carter marks his sixtieth year, the band enters one of the most personal and emotionally resonant chapters of its long history. It is the first Bloodkin project created since the passing of Carter's lifelong friend, songwriting partner and bandmate Daniel Hutchens in 2021, and rather than attempting to replace an irreplaceable creative partner, Carter chose instead to treat the record as both tribute and continuation, a focused, forty-minute collection meant to be heard from beginning to end with Hutchens's spirit woven through every track.

The album's latest single, "Drinkin' Blue," carries a particularly deep connection to Carter and Hutchens's shared history. Carter first wrote the song after entering rehab in 2008, when Hutchens drove him to treatment in Statesboro, returned

seven weeks later to bring him home, and welcomed him into his own house as Carter began rebuilding his life. As Carter recalls it, the song was the first tune he wrote after leaving rehab, though it never developed into a Bloodkin song at the time. It stayed with him for nearly two decades instead, its imagery of old photographs, notebooks and letters eventually finding a natural home among the album's broader reflections on memory and loss. Betsy Franck joins Carter on vocals for the track, while longtime collaborator John Neff adds pedal steel, drawing to the surface the deep vein of country music that has always run through Bloodkin's sound, a thread Carter traces back to childhood rides in his father's sky-blue pickup with country radio playing in the background.

Formed in 1986 by childhood best friends Carter and Hutchens, Bloodkin has built a devoted following over nearly four decades through eight

studio albums and a reputation for dynamic, hard-hitting live performances, carrying forward a legacy of pure, gritty, non-fiction rock and roll. The current lineup includes Carter and Franck on vocals and guitar, Tori Pater on vocals and guitar, Neff on guitar and pedal steel, Jon Mills on bass and Aaron Phillips on drums. The band remains closely tied to fellow Athens act Widespread Panic, who have covered Bloodkin songs since the 1990s, and the push and pull among the three musicians now sharing vocal duties creates an onstage chemistry that continues to seduce audiences, backed by storytelling, pedal steel and a rhythm section built to hit hard. Bloodkin is, by all accounts, best experienced live: raw, poetic, and immersive enough to leave a room feeling wrecked in the best possible way.



SCAN TO LISTEN
INDIEFFERENTIAL

DEEP DIVE

Walking the Tightrope: Stephanie Phillips Turns Grief Into Grace

Some albums are written to be heard. Others are written to survive something. For indie folk artist Stephanie Phillips, based in West Chester, Pennsylvania, her seventh studio album, *Walking the Tightrope*, is very much the latter, a deeply personal body of work shaped by a year and a half of profound emotional upheaval. Written in the wake of her brother's death and during the beginning of her marriage to her second husband, the record reflects the disorienting mix of grief, love, transition and resilience that defined that stretch of her life.

Across its tracks, *Walking the Tightrope* showcases Phillips's continued artistic evolution, blending her

signature introspective lyricism with a fuller, more confident sonic palette than her previous work, incorporating more instrumentation than any record she has made before. The album stands as both a creative milestone and a form of emotional processing, a testament to how art can hold the weight of a life in motion and transform it into something steady, honest and resonant. Born out of grief and joy in equal measure, and every emotion that sits between them, it captures a period defined less by resolution than by the difficult work of moving forward.

Phillips has been singing, playing guitar and writing music from an early age, building a career that has

taken her to venues across the United States, including well-known New York City clubs such as the *SpeakEasy* and the *Village Gate*. A particular highlight came in the 1990s, when she opened for Emmylou Harris, a moment that reflects the kind of company her songwriting has long kept. Phillips describes her music as "progressive folk," drawing inspiration from artists including Billy Joel, James Taylor and Dan Fogelberg, and her catalogue consistently takes listeners on a sonic journey through the full emotional range of life: love, loss, hope and despair. She has also never shied away from tackling social justice issues as they arise in the wider world, treating songwriting as a space for both personal and public reckoning.

"Others are written to survive something."

With *Walking the Tightrope*, Phillips continues that tradition while pushing further into vulnerability than perhaps any of her previous six albums allowed. The added instrumentation gives the

record a fuller sound than her earlier, more sparsely arranged work, matching the emotional density of what she was living through as she wrote it.

It is a record built from real loss and real love arriving at the same time, and it asks listeners to sit with both, rather than resolve them into anything tidier than what life actually offered her.





Knock Knock: Brewed Up Joe's Return to Raw Hip-Hop Basics

There is a particular pleasure in hearing hip-hop strip itself back down to essentials, and that is exactly the mission behind "Knock Knock," the new release from J/O/E, also known as Brewed Up Joe. Released on 28th August 2026, the track is a deliberate revert back to raw hip-hop basics: a heavy, mystic loop beat paired with unapologetic rhymes that carry both substance and a slight, knowing sense of humor.

THE STORY

J/O/E is an award-winning emcee, producer, influencer and self-described craft beer enthusiast from south Fort Worth, Texas, whose sound draws on boom bap rap, blues, jazz and a wide range of other musical traditions. Unlike the craft beer he clearly loves, his music is framed as anything but an acquired taste, built instead to appeal across demographics rather than to a narrow niche audience. That accessibility is paired with an evident hunger: inspired by life experience and what is described as an obsession to be great, J/O/E positions himself as a stylish, still-striving artist pushing past his own limits in search of new creative heights, hoping in the process to help pave the way for other up-and-coming artists following behind him.

"Knock Knock" itself is focused squarely on the basic mechanics of hip-hop: bars and a banging beat, nothing more ornamental required. Produced by Phil Kizer, a Connecticut native now based in Texas, the track brings raw and cunning bars back to the forefront, built to keep listeners' heads bobbing while slipping in a few gems worth living by along the way. It is unapologetic by design, a reminder that hip-hop doesn't need elaborate production tricks to hit hard when the fundamentals are handled with this much confidence.

The release also signals more to come. J/O/E has an upcoming album expected in the late fall, positioning "Knock Knock" as both a standalone statement and an opening chapter in a larger rollout. For an artist whose persona blends craft beer culture with genuine lyrical ambition, the track works as a kind of mission statement: strip away the excess, trust the bars, and let the beat do the rest.

It is old-school in spirit but delivered with enough personality and humor to feel entirely current, a knock at the door from an artist clearly intent on being let in, and confident enough in his fundamentals to make that entrance with nothing but bars and a beat, no gimmicks required to hold the room's attention.

PROFILE

TWENTY-ONE SONGS, ONE LIFETIME: RABBIT ON THE MOON'S MUSICAL MONUMENT TO LOVE

Most love songs capture a single feeling. Rabbit on the Moon is attempting something far larger: a monument. The independent project is built entirely around one continuing real-life love story, centered on May 21: A Love Story, a twenty-one-song autobiographical body of work transforming more than two decades of love, marriage, family and memory into music. The story began on 21st May 2005, the day the artist behind the project first saw the woman who would eventually become his wife, and each of the twenty-one songs is designed to preserve a different moment, memory or emotion from the life they have since built together.

The project's ambition extends well beyond simply documenting a relationship. Inspired by the idea that monuments such as the Taj Mahal have allowed people centuries later, across the world, to know that an extraordinary love once existed, Rabbit on the Moon attempts to build its own version of that permanence, not out of marble, but

out of music, carrying the hope that someone, long after the two people at its center are gone, might still hear these songs and know that they existed, that they found each other, and that they truly loved one another.

The Spanish-language single "Amor" offers one especially intimate chapter of that story. Drawn from a relationship that began more than twenty years ago, it recalls nights spent talking until sunrise, listening to love songs together, and translating their meaning from Spanish to English. Years later, the man who once translated other people's love songs for the woman he loved is now writing songs about her instead, turning that private ritual into part of the couple's own musical record. The song moves through longing, memory and reassurance before arriving at its central, plainly stated promise, one line of which puts it simply: "Siempre amor."

Musically, "Amor" sits between contemporary Latin pop and the romantic

ballad tradition, its restrained, melodic presentation keeping the focus squarely on vocal and lyric, letting phrases like "Te necesito, constantemente" carry the emotional weight without additional ornamentation.

For listeners encountering Rabbit on the Moon for the first time through this song, it stands on its own as a deeply personal love song. Within the wider context of May 21: A Love Story, however, it is simply one more preserved memory inside a much larger account, a husband still writing, twenty years on, for the wife who inspired all twenty-one songs, and who, if the project succeeds, will still be heard long after both of them are gone.





TAKE ME HIGHER: BLAKE RAVE TURNS RESILIENCE INTO A PARTY



SCAN TO LISTEN
INDIEFFERENTIAL

There is something refreshingly uncomplicated about "I'm On Fire," the latest release from Blake Rave's *Never Broken* album. At a time when feel-good music can sometimes drift into cliché, Rave keeps things direct and conversational, delivering an infectious, feel-good pop track built around energetic production, a memorable hook and a distinctive vocal, tailor-made for uplifting, driving, positive-vibes playlists. At its core, it is a song about waking up in the right frame of mind, leaving yesterday behind and embracing the day ahead.

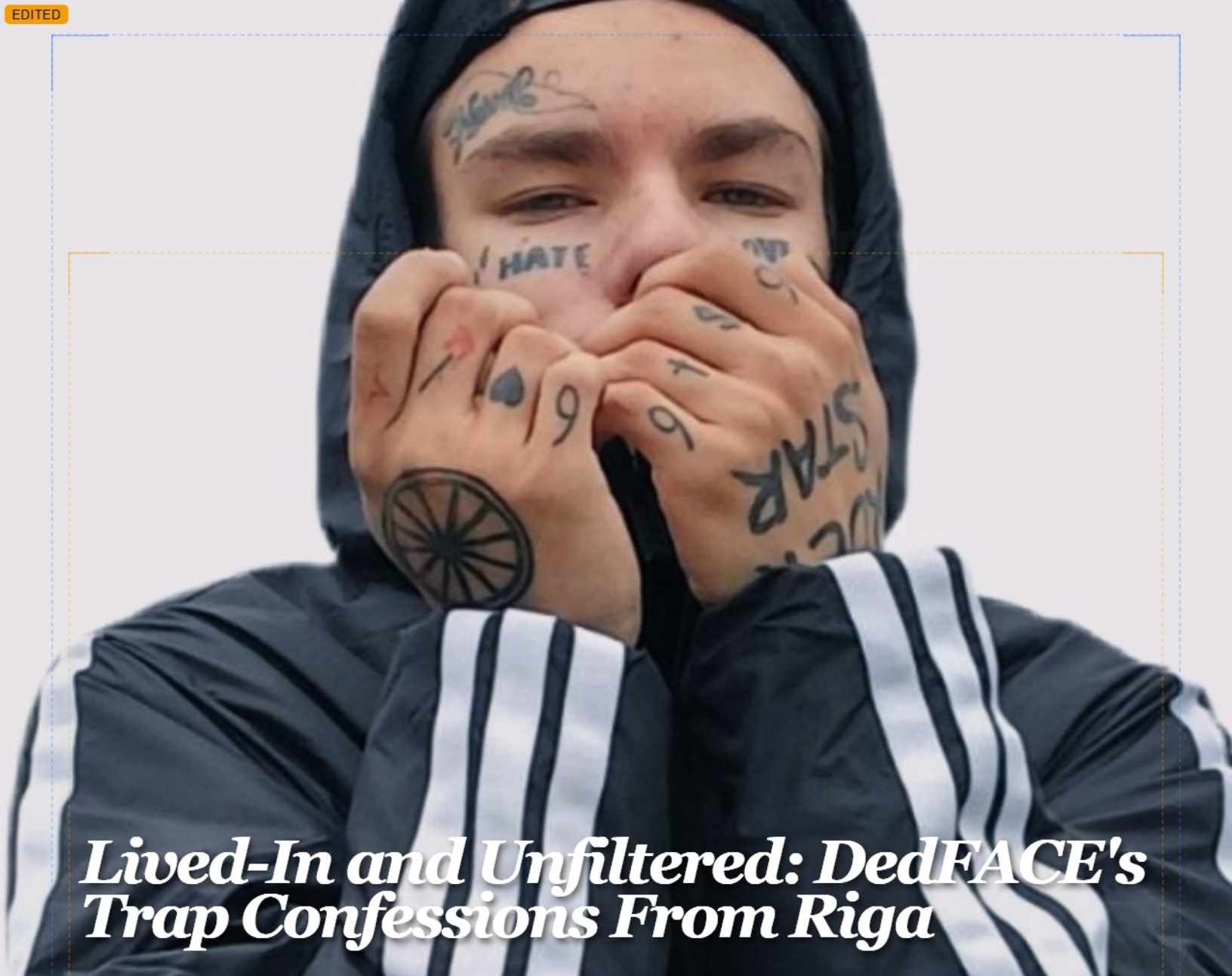
The opening lyric, "Woke up, it's a brand new day / Slept the drama away," sets that tone immediately. Paired with an upbeat groove and a recurring "I'm on fire / Take me higher" refrain, the track delivers its message through infectious energy rather than grand declarations, landing as positive without ever tipping into overly sentimental territory. There is also a

playful edge running through the writing, particularly in the line "Let the haters hate and let the players play," while a later verse offers direct encouragement to anyone navigating their own pressures: "It's time to shine, they can't steal your crown," a line that captures the song's central message that confidence and sense of self belong to no one but yourself.

That sentiment connects naturally to the wider *Never Broken* project. Where the album's title speaks to resilience in a broader sense, "I'm On Fire" explores what happens once resilience turns into renewed confidence, freedom and forward momentum, functioning as one bright chapter within a longer story rather than a standalone statement. As *Never Broken* has continued rolling out across multiple releases, each song has been given room to reach audiences individually while collectively building a fuller picture of Blake Rave as an artist.

More broadly, Rave is a singer-songwriter whose current project blends introspective storytelling with contemporary pop production, drawing from personal experience to explore themes of resilience, love and self-discovery, always balancing emotional honesty with a polished, modern sound. A voice that moves comfortably between vulnerability and strength gives the music a personal yet accessible quality, one that resonates with listeners drawn to heartfelt, melody-driven pop.

"I'm On Fire" stands as one of the most immediately positive expressions of that identity, an invitation rather than a lecture, less about telling listeners to feel better and more about handing them a reason to turn the volume up and feel it for themselves. Rooted in individuality and perseverance, it captures a moment when resilience finally turns outward into celebration.



Lived-In and Unfiltered: DedFACE's Trap Confessions From Riga

Some artists build a persona to hide behind. DedFACE has built his entire sound around refusing to. Dmitrijs Vasenovs, better known by that name, is an independent artist from Riga, Latvia, who since his 2023 debut has carved out a distinctive niche by blending raw honesty with genuine emotional volatility rather than smoothing either into something more comfortable to package.

That approach is deeply informed by his own personal journey, including transparency around his mental health, specifically an F44 dissociative disorder diagnosis that serves as a foundation for the visceral, lived-in quality of his storytelling. Rather than treating that diagnosis as something to obscure, DedFACE lets it shape the emotional texture of his music directly, giving his tracks an unpredictable intensity that feels closer to confession than performance.

His latest work continues in that vein while also embracing a more straightforward

mission: sometimes, as he puts it, listeners simply want to blast something aggressive at a party and forget all their problems for a while. The track in question deals with gangs and crime, delivered with an intensity meant to hit hard rather than moralize, inviting listeners to put it on and experience what he frames as real trap in its purest, most unfiltered form.

That tension between confessional vulnerability and pure sonic aggression is arguably what makes DedFACE stand out within a crowded trap landscape. Where much of the genre trades in exaggerated bravado, his music carries an undercurrent of instability drawn directly from lived experience, an emotional volatility that feels earned rather than performed for effect. It is aggressive music built from a place of genuine personal difficulty, rather than aggression used simply as a stylistic pose.

Operating independently from Riga rather than through any larger industry apparatus,

DedFACE has steadily built a body of work defined less by polish than by rawness, using his platform to be transparent about mental health in a genre not always known for that kind of openness.

The result is music that functions on two levels at once: as party-ready trap built for maximum immediate impact, and as an ongoing act of personal disclosure from an artist willing to let his diagnosis, and the emotional unpredictability that comes with it, sit right at the surface of the work rather than hidden somewhere underneath it. Since his 2023 debut, that combination has become the closest thing DedFACE has to a signature, an artist whose loudest, most aggressive tracks are, in their own way, also his most honest.



Q & A

Fragile Rebels, Found Together: The Restless Few's Anthem for Outsiders



The Restless Few trace their roots back more than two decades, to childhood friendships formed in Bologna, Italy, long before the band relocated to London and took on its current shape. This ragtag collective of lifelong friends has been writing music together since primary school, surviving countless demos, abandoned projects and what became an epic search for the perfect lead singer, a search that ultimately led them down an unexpected creative path entirely.

THE STORY

Drawing inspiration from artists including AWOLNATION, Nothing But Thieves, Muse, Elbow and Radiohead, the band crafts music that wanders freely between raw rock energy, polished pop hooks and cinematic electronic atmospheres. Their sound is defined by layered synths, dynamic contrasts and arrangements that evolve from intimate confessions into expansive, communal anthems, a structure that mirrors the band's own long, winding journey toward finding its voice. Notably, The Restless Few have embraced AI-

assisted vocal technology not as a replacement for artistry but as a creative instrument in its own right, a tool that has finally allowed them to share the deeply human songs they had been sitting on for years, proof that technology can provide a voice while only genuine emotion and two decades of friendship can provide a soul.

That theme of finding a voice runs directly into new single "Born Astray," which feels like a natural continuation of the band's earlier track "The Restless Few." Where that song introduced the group's identity as outsiders, late starters and self-described "fragile rebels," "Born Astray" turns that identity into a broader celebration of difference itself. The song isn't really about being lost; instead, "astray" becomes a way of describing people who don't naturally follow the expected route, who feel slightly out of step with the crowd but find strength in recognising that same restlessness in others.

Crucially, the song's defiance is never purely individualistic. At its center sit brotherhood,

communal spirit and mutual recognition, with being different mattering less as an act of separation than as a way of finding one another. Recurring images of fragility, resistance and non-conformity are balanced throughout by lines about love, loyalty and looking toward each other rather than away.

In that sense, "Born Astray" extends the world The Restless Few first sketched out years earlier: the idea that difference becomes less isolating, and considerably more powerful, the moment it is shared with people who understand it, which is fitting for a band whose entire existence traces back to friendships that have already survived two decades of false starts.



SCAN TO LISTEN
INDIEFFERENTIAL

BEHIND THE RECORD

From Concert Halls to AI Vocals: Sharon Eitan's Anthem for Global Cooperation

KEEP AI UNDER CONTROL



Sharon Eitan's musical path has taken an unusually wide arc. He began as a composer of art music, writing orchestral and chamber works performed internationally by prominent ensembles, before shifting toward computer science and physics and later writing musicals. More recently, he has turned to releasing pop-rock songs built through an unusual process: recording elaborate demos himself, then producing the finished versions using AI vocals, always working to capture the exact mood and expression present in the original demo rather than letting the technology reshape the emotional intent.

Eitan's lyrics tend to be reflective and philosophical, drawing on the same

intellectual curiosity that carried him from concert halls into science and back into songwriting. His recent output includes "Doodle," about making the most of the present moment, "Crete," about nostalgia and rebellion, and "A pile of shoelaces," which takes aim at corruption within the entertainment industry. Taken together, these songs suggest an artist using pop-rock as a vehicle for ideas that might otherwise have stayed confined to more academic or theatrical forms.

His latest release, "Dario Amodei," marks a notable exception to that reflective tone. The song is a direct response to an essay by Anthropic's chief executive titled "We must pace the frontier," in which Amodei called for a slowdown in the development of

artificial intelligence given the risks involved. Eitan wrote the single as a simple, anthem-like tune, hoping it would resonate with people across different backgrounds and help promote Amodei's vision of international cooperation on AI safety. Notably, the song's lyrics include a direct call to presidents Trump and Xi, urging them to work together on the issue.

As Eitan puts it himself, "I may be naïve, but I believe a song can make a difference," a statement that captures both the earnestness and the ambition behind the project.

It is a striking pivot for an artist whose career began in the rarefied world of orchestral composition: rather than

retreating from big, contested global questions, Eitan has chosen pop songwriting, paired with AI-assisted vocal production, as his chosen instrument for engaging with one of the more consequential debates of the moment. That same instinct, to take a large abstract issue and translate it into something a listener can hum, runs through much of his catalogue, even in songs with far less obviously political subject matter.

Whether or not the song reaches the audience he hopes it will, "Dario Amodei" stands as a clear statement of intent from an artist unwilling to separate his music from his convictions about where technology and global politics might be headed next.



WHERE HIGH HEELS MEET HI-VIS: DREAMGOOD'S FORTUNE-TELLING POP ODYSSEY

DreamGood have never been interested in staying inside neat genre lines, and their new single "Lifeline" makes that clear from the first listen. Described by the band as a soft-boy introvert's anthem about believing in your own innate intuition, the track has been likened to Adele commingling with Aphex Twin, an electronic, weirdo alt-pop offering aimed squarely at fans of Perfume Genius, Four Tet, Belinda Carlisle and George Michael. It marks the second single from their forthcoming concept album, Paris Novella (Fortune Teller), a project built to explore a kaleidoscope of emotion and ideas, inviting listeners to think, dance and flex in the mirror right alongside it.

DreamGood is a cinematic art-pop trio made up of Mitchell

Sloan, Joshua Heath and Glenn Heath, together since 2009. Across that time, the group has developed a sound built on poetic pop-ballad lyricism, electronic textures and immersive production, one designed to move fluidly between dancefloors, dream states and confessional inner worlds. They have shared stages with acts including Victoria, Pseudo Echo, Scattered Order and Fables, and have picked up enthusiastic reviews from a range of blogs and magazines along the way.

The full scope of their new direction arrives with Paris Novella (Fortune Teller): All Predictions Act Like Curses, a concept album that pushes into new territory sonically, lyrically and conceptually by entering the world of an eccentric fortune teller named

Paris. Since the release of their first album, DreamGood describe themselves as having propelled into what they call an existential black hole of character-inspired pop, using that fictional framework to explore themes and emotions that might feel too exposed delivered in a purely autobiographical form.

Exploring a kaleidoscope of emotions and ideas throughout, the album invites listeners to engage physically and emotionally at once, treating pop music as something to be danced to and thought about in equal measure.

DreamGood continue to carve out a genuinely distinctive identity in that space, one built where pop, experimentation and eccentric storytelling collide without apology,

captured neatly in their own description of the aesthetic: a place where high heels are worn with hi-vis. It's an image that says as much about the band's sensibility as any single song could, glamour and grit refusing to cancel each other out, existing instead side by side inside the same restless, character-driven world they have been building together since 2009, one strange, danceable, character-filled new release at a time.



FEATURE

CHOOSING YOURSELF: ROSES AND RAIN'S SUN-SOAKED ANTHEM OF SELF-LOVE



There is a particular kind of freedom that comes from simply walking away, and Roses and Rain capture it beautifully on their dreamy, uplifting new song "Until Further Notice." The track centers on finding freedom, embracing self-love and reconnecting with who you truly are, blending hazy synth textures with an intimate acoustic sensibility that unfolds through warm, layered female harmonies and evocative pop production.

Nostalgic yet refreshingly light, "Until Further Notice" captures the specific feeling of letting go, of leaving everything behind and choosing yourself instead, without ever tipping into melodrama. Its sun-soaked atmosphere conjures images of beach escapes, open-road drives along the coast and endless summer horizons, functioning as a kind of soundtrack for those moments when the only thing left to do is breathe, reset and find a way back to oneself. It is escapism built not from denial, but

from clarity, the sound of someone finally giving themselves permission to slow down.

Roses and Rain is the songwriting duo of Sarah Rose and Leila Reine, whose music draws on their collective roots spread across London, Tokyo and Nashville, three very different musical cities whose influence shows up in the breadth of the duo's sound. Blending dreamy pop textures with folk influences, the pair have developed a sound that is both catchy and cinematic, pairing evocative songwriting with an intimate emotional core that keeps even their most atmospheric productions feeling personal rather than distant.

Through story-led songwriting, Roses and Rain consistently explore themes of female empowerment, freedom and human connection, bringing together vivid, personal lyrics with emotive pop production to create music that manages to feel both intimate and

expansive at once. "Until Further Notice" fits neatly into that broader body of work, using the specific imagery of sunlight, open roads and shifting horizons to make a much simpler point universal: that choosing yourself, even temporarily, even without a clear plan for what comes next, can be its own quiet act of empowerment.

Drawing on three very different corners of the globe for their collective musical identity, Sarah Rose and Leila Reine have built a partnership defined by warmth and clarity in equal measure, and "Until Further Notice" stands as one of their most fully realized statements yet of what that partnership sounds like in practice.

It is a song that trusts stillness as much as movement, content to let its sun-soaked atmosphere do the emotional work rather than reaching for a bigger, more dramatic gesture.



SCAN TO LISTEN
INDIEFFERENTIAL

SPOTLIGHT

NO STUDIO TRICKS: FILIPOVICH'S UNPLUGGED SESSION FROM MINSK



There is a particular kind of honesty that only comes through when the studio tricks disappear entirely, and that is precisely the territory Minsk-based indie rock band Filipovich occupy on 'Vzaperti,' a raw, intimate three-track Studio Live session inspired by the iconic MTV Unplugged era. Trading digital production for warm acoustic tones and single-take vulnerability, the release captures the honest, melancholic energy of musicians playing together in one room, with no overdubs and no studio tricks standing between the performance and the listener.

Recommended for anyone who loves heartfelt, atmospheric songwriting and classic live acoustic rock, the session sits comfortably alongside touchstones like Nirvana's Unplugged set or acoustic Radiohead, offering pure, authentic indie rock delivered straight from Eastern Europe without any of the polish that typically softens a studio recording.

THE STORY

Filipovich itself is a compelling rock outfit built on serendipity and shared passion as much as on musicianship. The band came together by chance in Minsk, Belarus, united by a common love of rock music even as each member brought distinctly different musical tastes into the mix, a combination that ultimately produces a uniquely textured sound rather than a diluted one. At the heart of the project is Natalia Filipovich, who writes both lyrics and music while delivering the band's captivating lead vocals. She is supported by Vladimir Burshnev on bass guitar and guitar, who shapes much of the band's arrangements, and Elisey Kapranov on drums, who also handles the group's recording and production duties. A little later, Alexey Ignatenko joined the lineup, stepping into the role of bass guitarist as the band's configuration evolved.

That convergence of genuinely different influences is a large part of what sets Filipovich apart from

more typical rock acts, producing a dynamic internal chemistry that comes through clearly on record. The band has also built a strong reputation as a live act, regularly performing at venues across Minsk, with one particularly iconic festival performance even earning broadcast time on local television, a notable milestone for an independent rock band operating outside the usual channels of the wider international scene.

'Vzaperti' distills all of that into its most stripped-back form yet: no digital sheen, no safety net, just four musicians in a room letting their differences and their shared passion for rock music speak entirely for themselves.

For a band built on chance encounters and mismatched tastes finding common ground, an unplugged session feels like the most honest possible test, and one Filipovich passes without needing a single overdub to prove it.



CALIFORNIA SOUL, SHARED: SOUTH SWELL SYNDICATE'S FEEL-GOOD DEBUT



Some bands are built around a single frontperson's vision. South Swell Syndicate was built instead around a shared sensibility, one carried by musicians who already knew exactly what California sunshine is supposed to sound like. Founded in 2024, the SoCal collective blends surf rock, reggae and influences spanning multiple genres and generations, bringing together members of Tribal Seeds, Long Beach Dub Allstars and Rebelution into a single project united by feel-good melodies and thoughtful, positive lyrics.

The group was founded by Mick Attardo and Lewis Richards alongside the team at 17th Street Recording Studio, a foundation that shaped the collaborative, community-minded spirit running through the project from its earliest days. Rather than positioning itself as any one member's solo vehicle, South Swell Syndicate functions as a genuine syndicate in the truest sense, pooling experience from several respected acts within the reggae and surf-adjacent scenes to create something with a distinct identity of its own, rather than simply sounding like a side project of any single contributing band.

That identity finds its fullest expression on the group's debut album, *Go Where I Please*, a record designed to deliver exactly the kind of soundtrack its title implies: beach days, road trips and laid-back afternoons with nowhere urgent to be. The album

leans fully into unmistakable California soul, marrying surf rock's bright, rolling guitar work with reggae's unhurried rhythmic pulse, all wrapped around lyrics that favor optimism and positive messaging over cynicism or complexity for its own sake.

What makes South Swell Syndicate notable within a crowded field of surf-and-reggae acts is precisely that pedigree, members drawn from bands already well regarded within their respective scenes, choosing to combine forces rather than simply continue on separate paths. The result carries a certain easy confidence, the sound of musicians who have already spent years honing their individual crafts elsewhere now applying that experience toward something collectively looser and sunnier, with none of the strain that can come from a band still figuring out its own chemistry in real time.

Go Where I Please doesn't strain for reinvention; instead, it commits fully to a mood, one built for beach days and long drives rather than dense lyrical analysis, and lets that commitment do the work. For a band named after the pull of the swell itself, that feels entirely appropriate: music meant to be caught, ridden and enjoyed, rather than dissected, and shared with a playlist rather than picked apart in the liner notes.

SCENE REPORT

Nineteen Releases In: Ronald Hage's Handmade Approach to Dance Music

Don't Wanna Lose This



Consistency is its own kind of statement, and few independent electronic producers demonstrate that quite as clearly as Ronald Hage. A dedicated melodic house and progressive house producer from The Hague in the Netherlands, Hage has spent several years crafting dancefloor-ready tracks, and his new single, "Don't Wanna Lose This," marks his nineteenth release after eighteen months of consistent output, a testament to both his prolific work rate and his commitment to releasing new material roughly every four to six weeks.

The new track is a contemporary electronic production where melody, energy and atmosphere blend seamlessly, combining influences from melodic techno, progressive house and trance as it carefully builds toward a powerful, immersive climax. Throughout, Hage remains focused on a specific balance: finding the sweet spot between a modern dance sound, genuinely memorable melodies and a musical identity distinctly his own, rather than simply

chasing whatever currently dominates dancefloors elsewhere.

That identity has been shaped in large part by leading progressive house artists including Korolova, Miss Monique and Youna, whose influence shows up in Hage's ability to move comfortably between vocal-driven and purely instrumental productions. What separates his process from many of his peers, however, is a deliberate insistence on craftsmanship over automation. Working entirely from his home studio, Hage maintains an authentic, hands-on approach to music creation, notably eschewing AI and auto-arrangement programs in favor of building each track by hand.

His creative process typically begins away from the computer entirely, at an acoustic piano, where he discovers the melodic foundations of a new track before translating them into his digital audio workstation and gradually layering in drums and synthesizers around that initial idea.

It's a workflow that inverts the more common electronic-music approach of starting inside the software and working outward, and it gives Hage's tracks a melodic backbone that feels composed rather than assembled.

Nineteen releases in less than two years is a considerable pace by any standard, but Hage's insistence on beginning each track at the piano, and building everything else by hand from there, suggests an artist less interested in volume for its own sake than in maintaining a consistent, deliberate creative discipline, one track and one melody at a time.

In an electronic music landscape increasingly shaped by automated tools and templated arrangements, that piano-first, hands-on discipline is what gives "Don't Wanna Lose This," and the eighteen releases that preceded it, a sense of having been genuinely composed rather than assembled.



SCAN TO LISTEN
INDIEFFERENTIAL

FROM IDOL STAGE TO HIS OWN WORLD: SEBASTIAN RYDGREN'S GLITTERING NEW CHAPTER



Sebastian Rydgren's musical journey began on a very public stage. The Swedish artist, songwriter and DJ first rose to national attention as a standout contestant on Swedish Idol in 2022, quickly becoming an audience favorite and advancing all the way to the semi-finals. His talent caught the attention of Idol's chairman of the jury, internationally renowned producer and songwriter Anders Bagge, known for his work with Madonna, Celine Dion and Robyn, who went on to connect Rydgren with a range of other songwriters and producers. Before settling on his own name, Rydgren had previously released music under the monikers NORR and San Sebastian.

In the years since his Idol breakthrough, Rydgren has worked purposefully to develop an expression entirely his own, one built around modern pop, personal storytelling and a contemporary, forward-looking sound. That evolution is rooted in a strong musical education: growing up in Järfälla, outside Stockholm, he studied singer-songwriting at Rytmus before furthering his training through the Global Songwriting Program at Musikmakarna, where he continues his studies today while commuting between Stockholm and Örnköldsvik. Alongside developing his own artistry, he has also written music for other artists, a parallel career that has clearly sharpened his instincts as a songwriter in his own right.

That growth reached a milestone in June 2026 with the release of his debut EP, *Midnight Confessions Pt. 1*, a collection of personal songs that marked a genuine new chapter in his artistry, moving him further from interpretation and closer to fully authored work. With his latest single, "glitter in my eyes," Rydgren takes the next step in that same direction, continuing a journey that has carried him from interpreting the creative visions of others toward fully shaping a musical world of his own.

Known for his emotive voice, modern pop sound and magnetic stage presence, Rydgren has spent the years since Idol building something more durable than a single television moment, choosing collaboration and formal songwriting education over simply capitalizing on early exposure.

The arc from reality-show favorite to independent artist crafting his own EPs is not an unusual one in pop music, but Rydgren's steady, education-driven approach to it, paired with his continued work writing for other artists, suggests a career built on genuine craft rather than a single fleeting moment of national attention. His connection to Anders Bagge, a producer with a track record spanning Madonna, Celine Dion and Robyn, only underscores how far that early Idol exposure has carried him since.



SCAN TO LISTEN
INDEPENDENT

FIRST LISTEN

HOPE IN THE ASHES: NIEL LIAN'S SOLO PIANO MEDITATION ON FRAGILITY

Resilience does not always look heroic, and Niel Lian's twelve-track solo piano album, *Resilience in a World on Fire*, is built almost entirely around that idea. Rather than framing resilience as some kind of triumphant resistance, the album follows a more intimate, non-linear journey through fear, healing, identity, movement, and small moments of light and gratitude, exploring themes of fragility, distance, absence and belonging, along with the many different ways people learn to live with uncertainty.

The record expands on ideas first introduced in Lian's 2025 debut EP of the same name, combining new compositions with pieces revisited and refined for this new recording, this time performed on an acoustic piano rather than the more digital textures of the earlier release. That shift in instrumentation matters: it grounds the album's themes in something warmer and more physically present, letting each note carry the weight of the emotional territory being explored.

THE STORY

The twelve pieces are designed to function as individual stories in their own right while gradually forming a broader narrative across the album as a whole, one in which hope is allowed to coexist with fragility rather than replace it, even while, as the title suggests, the world outside remains very much on fire. It is an approach that resists easy resolution, treating uncertainty not as a problem to be solved by the music but as a condition to be sat with and, eventually, gently reframed.

Niel Lian is an Italian pianist and composer with classical training in piano and additional studies in modern composition, and that dual foundation shows clearly in his sound, which brings together elements of classical tradition with contemporary minimalism. His influences span Chopin and Philip Glass through to Wim Mertens, Max Richter, Nils Frahm and Felix Rösch, alongside what he describes as the psychologically aware approach of Peter

Gabriel, an unusual reference point for a solo piano composer but one that speaks to his interest in emotional precision over technical display.

Taken as a whole, *Resilience in a World on Fire* reads less like a collection of piano pieces and more like a quiet act of processing, twelve individual meditations that add up to something considerably larger: a reminder that fragility and hope are not opposites, but companions capable of existing in the very same measure of music.

The move from the 2025 EP's arrangements to a full acoustic piano recording gives these ideas a second life, one that trades any remaining digital distance for something closer to the sound of a single instrument thinking out loud.



SCAN TO LISTEN
INDIEFFERENTIAL

N I E L L I A N



THREE CONTINENTS, ONE BOW: WILLIAM ROBLEJO'S GLOBAL CUBAN SYMPHONY

Cuban violinist William Roblejo has spent his career proving that a single instrument, in the right hands, can carry an entire cultural conversation. His upcoming fourth album, *After The Waves*, pushes that idea further than ever, bringing together musicians from Cuba, Iran and Spain in an ambitious international collaboration spanning three continents. Created over more than three years, the album explores the meeting point between Cuban musical tradition and contemporary sounds, filtered through a genuinely diverse range of international influences. *After The Waves* is set for full release on 20th October.

The project is masterminded by Mo Fini, with production credited to Fini alongside Roblejo, Christophe Rezai, Dayron Ortiz and David Alvarez, a creative team whose varied backgrounds contribute directly to the album's distinctive international character. Leading the project with his unmistakable Cuban voice and characteristic virtuosity, Roblejo connects artists and traditions from around the world

into a single, deeply collaborative musical journey, one built as much on cultural exchange as on musicianship.

That collaborative instinct is rooted in a formidable musical education and career. A graduate of Cuba's prestigious Instituto Superior de Arte, Roblejo has built a career distinguished by musical excellence, versatility and a consistent willingness to explore beyond conventional boundaries. He was a founding member of the contemporary music quartet Traza and a member of the Amadeo Roldán String Quartet, affiliated with the Cuban Philharmonic, and between 2007 and 2011 he performed as part of the group led by prominent Cuban singer-songwriter David Torrens, further broadening his experience across Cuba's contemporary music landscape.

Alongside his work as a performer and recording artist, Roblejo has made a significant contribution to the next generation of Cuban musicians, currently serving as Head of the String Department at the

Amadeo Roldán Conservatory, one of Cuba's most distinguished institutions for musical education. His fourth album draws all of these dimensions together at once: performer, composer, collaborator, educator and musical explorer, each role feeding directly into the finished work.

More than simply a violinist, Roblejo has given the instrument a personality and voice entirely his own, one that remains unmistakably Cuban even as it grows increasingly international in scope. His distinctive zeal and virtuosity have earned him a respected place among the leading figures of Cuba's vibrant music scene, a reputation that *After The Waves* seems designed to extend well beyond it.

By connecting musicians from Cuba, Iran and Spain within a single project, three countries spanning three continents, *After The Waves* stands as a clear demonstration of music's capacity to transcend language, geography and borders altogether.



LEARNING TO SHRED, LEARNING TO SCREAM: THE ORIGIN OF LIMIT STATE

Every great rock band needs an origin story, and Limit State's began with a promise. Singer and composer Damien Easton had already recorded two projects alongside guitarist Dave Wolfberg, including *The Dark Corners* in 2020 and *The Stars*, a 2023 collaboration with Jimmie Herrod, yet neither had truly showcased what Wolfberg was capable of on guitar. Realizing this, Easton

made a resolution: to write something where Wolfberg could really shred.

Early sketches didn't amount to much beyond the intention itself, but in the spring of 2024 a wave of inspiration hit, and the entire album was written within a couple of months. That burst of creativity involved more than just songwriting; it also required a woodshed period

for vocal technique, during which Easton finally learned how to properly sing rock music. Having initially considered hiring another vocalist for the project, he instead chose to test his own capabilities, and the resulting combination of intensive vocal training and rapid, almost feverish writing and demoing amounted to something close to a mystical experience, effectively birthing an entirely new musical entity in Limit State.

"Realizing this, Easton made a resolution: to write something where Wolfberg could really shred."

The project marks Easton's full return to rock after nearly twenty years away from the genre, a period during which he earned a master's degree in composition, taught as a professor of music theory, and recorded both experimental pop and contemporary classical music. Limit State is shaped by all of that accumulated experience, yet remains, by design, purely rock at its core. Easton and Wolfberg reunited with bassist Nicolas Dinucci and producer Chris King of Moon Palace Productions, who had previously worked with Easton on his solo album *The Dark Corners*, before bringing drummer Till Richter on board to complete the lineup.

Sonically, Limit State draws on grunge, prog, metal and post-punk and indie influences, heard clearly on tracks like "Out Loud," which carries driving punk energy alongside janky, jagged disruptions, a genuinely dissonant shredding solo, and vocals that hold back before finally erupting into big rock screams. Lyrically, the band first addresses the collective experience of a world contracting in some ways while growing rapidly and chaotically in others, before turning more personal, exploring how those large-scale systemic pressures embed themselves inside an individual life: alienation, a longing for something real, and the humbling realization of being part of the problem. The

album is built to take listeners on an emotional journey, ideally leaving them somewhere different from where they began.







Spotlight

e.lissa faden Turns Quiet Rage Into Hypnotic Darkness on "Cement"



Photo by Ima Leupp

Anger does not always arrive loudly. Sometimes it lingers beneath the surface, gathering weight until it becomes impossible to ignore. On "Cement", Austin artist e.lissa faden transforms that restrained tension into a dark and hypnotic piece of trip hop, creating a song that feels sensual, unsettling and slightly detached from reality.

Released as part of faden's debut EP "Daisy Chain", "Cement" inhabits the shadowy space that defines much of her music. The track draws heavily from the hazy production and hypnotic rhythms associated with 1990s and early 2000s trip hop, while incorporating elements of alternative rock, grunge and electronic music. The result is nostalgic without sounding trapped in the past, giving familiar textures a contemporary emotional intensity.

The song begins quietly, allowing its tension to accumulate rather than announcing itself immediately. As the arrangement develops, that restraint gradually gives way to something darker and more visceral. The effect is almost cinematic, like a siren drawing someone closer while offering no indication of what waits at the other end. Seduction and danger occupy the same space, creating an atmosphere that feels deliberately unresolved.

The emotional starting point for "Cement" was anger. Faden wrote the song during a burst of catharsis, beginning with a question about what it might feel like

to return the pain inflicted by another person directly to its source. That initial impulse toward revenge becomes more complicated as the song unfolds.

For faden, the track ultimately became less about retaliation and more about understanding anger before letting it go. The fantasy of seeing the balance reversed can offer a temporary sense of power, but the greater strength lies in refusing to remain attached to the experience. That distinction gives "Cement" an emotional depth that extends beyond its dark atmosphere.

The accompanying visualizer, shot by Ima Leupp of Seamless Loop Productions, strengthens that feeling without attempting to explain the song literally. Instead, the imagery creates a physical counterpart to its disorienting emotional landscape. Familiar elements become strange, reinforcing faden's fascination with liminal spaces and moments where reality feels slightly displaced.

That aesthetic extends across "Daisy Chain", which faden describes as a backlit hallway that is both unsettling and intriguing. The EP seems designed to create precisely that contradiction, inviting listeners into an environment they may initially hesitate to enter, only to find themselves drawn further inside.

Produced by Austin's glitter grunge artist Dossey and engineered by J.J. Plasencio, known for work with Plumb

and Sixpence None the Richer, "Daisy Chain" balances atmospheric production with raw emotional writing. "Cement" sits at the centre of that approach, using hypnotic rhythm and restrained intensity to explore feelings that are uncomfortable but recognizably human.

Faden's previous single, "Unscathed", has already received attention from KOOP Radio's "Emo Diaries" and "Beat Happenings", while music journalist Simão Reis described the broader project as occupying a space where certainty continually slips away. That description suits "Cement", where nothing is entirely stable. Attraction can feel threatening, anger can become catharsis, and darkness can eventually become a place of release.

With its accompanying visualizer and the wider world of "Daisy Chain", "Cement" introduces an artist who understands atmosphere as more than decoration. Every sound and image contributes to an emotional environment where vulnerability, rage, memory and desire can exist simultaneously. Rather than simply escaping darkness, faden sits inside it long enough to understand what it has to say, then begins looking for a way out.



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